This characterisation challenges the current belief in a general pattern of growth for the emerging economies. It emphasises that these economies are competing among themselves while being situated in a generally stable, overall framework, where success for one country conspires against the possibilities for its rivals who are located on the same level of development. These intermediate economies repeat the trajectory taken by previous cohorts on the semi-periphery who also sought to climb the rungs up to the centre. But global segmentation always impedes collective success. If China's expansion is consolidated, it will only go to underscore the exceptional nature of its leap. Entering the ranks of the developed countries is beyond the reach of the other BRICS, MINTs or EAGLES.

Scattered sub-powers

The regional geopolitical role of each semi-peripheral economy is crucial for its success or failure; this determines whether it is able to occupy an empty spot in the global order. Some countries included in this segment are enormous, boasting truly continental dimensions, but some have also suffered frustrated imperial intentions. They began as powers but ended up as semi-colonies and had to fall back on plans for constructing a limited, regional domination. Russia, India, and Turkey especially share these peculiarities. These nations are spread out over huge territories and control important demographic or natural resources, and they are able to negotiate directly with the Triad. Their geopolitical capacity for action directly influences their location in the semi-peripheral ranking.

Many analysts estimate that these countries will tend to converge in common blocs in order to contend with the central powers. However, clear indications of this coming together are few and far between, and the disparate treatment meted out to each by imperialism only makes this convergence less likely. For instance, the United States is hostile to Russia, but it is closely associated with Turkey and is rebuilding its relationship with India. Instead of forming a bloc, each sub-power seeks its own niche within the neoliberal order. They accept free trade, the primacy of the transnational corporations, and the continuity of cross-border financial flows. In contrast to what occurred during the 1930s, there has been no attempt to erect protectionist networks, nor to construct militarist coalitions.

All the players have agreed to work within the existing international organisations to reinforce their own influence. They promote reforms to the voting system within the IMF and propose the creation of global reserve funds in hopes of gradually replacing the dollar. Since they have no interest in abruptly replacing the currency in which they hold the bulk of their reserves, they are